

WAR ON IRAN: The 2026 Middle East Crisis

How a Decades-Long Rivalry Erupted into Full-Scale Conflict — Operation Epic Fury, the Death of Khamenei, and a Region on the Brink

By the Global Affairs Review Editorial Team | Updated: March 20, 2026

KEY FACTS AT A GLANCE

• **Start of current conflict:** February 28, 2026 • **Operation name (US/Israel):** Operation Epic Fury • **First-day strikes:** ~900 in 12 hours targeting Iran • **Death of Supreme Leader:** Ali Khamenei killed Feb. 28, 2026 • **Death toll (Iran):** 1,444+ confirmed dead; 2,000+ wounded • **Deaths in Israel:** At least 18 civilians killed • **US military fatalities:** 13 confirmed • **Strait of Hormuz:** Closed by Iranian action • **Countries affected:** Iran, Israel, Lebanon, Bahrain, Iraq, Kuwait, Jordan

BACKGROUND: HOW IT BEGAN

The roots of the 2026 Iran War stretch back decades. Once close allies between 1948 and 1979, Israel and Iran became bitter enemies after the Iranian Revolution, which brought an anti-Western Islamic regime to power. The new government in Tehran viewed both the United States and Israel as the primary sources of grievance across the Middle East, setting the stage for a proxy conflict that would define regional geopolitics for generations.

The immediate triggers for the 2026 conflict were numerous. Iran's nuclear program — the subject of international controversy since the early 2000s — re-emerged as a flash point after the collapse of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA). The United States had withdrawn from the deal in 2018 under President Trump, reimposing crippling sanctions. Attempts in 2025 and 2026 to negotiate a new nuclear framework ultimately failed, with Washington demanding a permanent end to all uranium enrichment — a condition Iran rejected outright.

Iran's regional position had been steadily eroding. Israel's decapitation of Hezbollah's leadership in Lebanon in late 2024, combined with the fall of Syrian President Bashar al-Assad — a key Iranian ally — in December 2024, left Tehran's 'Axis of Resistance' badly diminished. The June 2025 Twelve-Day War further degraded Iran's air defenses and set back its nuclear program by an estimated two years. Inside Iran, a collapsing economy triggered mass protests in December 2025 and January 2026. Security forces responded with a deadly crackdown that, according to Iran's own Ministry of Health, killed at least 30,000 people.

"The attacks targeted Iranian missiles and air defenses, other military infrastructure, and Iranian leadership."

OPERATION EPIC FURY: THE OPENING SALVO

On the morning of February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel launched a coordinated surprise offensive against Iran — codenamed Operation Epic Fury by US Central Command. In just the first twelve

hours, US and Israeli forces conducted nearly 900 strikes against targets across Iran. The assault was unprecedented in scale, targeting air defenses, ballistic missile infrastructure, nuclear facilities, and Iranian leadership.

The most consequential strike of the opening day was the targeted killing of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei at a compound in Tehran. The death of the 86-year-old cleric — who had ruled Iran since 1989 — sent shockwaves through the region and triggered an immediate wave of Iranian retaliatory fire. Within hours, Iran began launching waves of ballistic missiles and drones at Israel, US military bases across the Middle East, and Arab states hosting American forces.

US Central Command Commander Admiral Brad Cooper confirmed that American forces were delivering what he described as 'devastating combat power against the Iranian regime,' noting that targeting efforts focused not only on immediate threats but on eliminating Iran's future strike capabilities. The Armed Conflict Location and Event Data (ACLED) project documented nearly 2,000 distinct events across at least 29 of Iran's 31 provinces, with Tehran suffering the heaviest bombardment.

IRAN'S RETALIATION

Iran responded swiftly and across multiple fronts. Ballistic missiles and suicide drones rained down on Israel, while Iranian forces simultaneously targeted US military installations in Bahrain, Kuwait, Iraq, and Qatar. The US Navy's 5th Fleet headquarters in Bahrain's Juffair district was struck multiple times. In central Israel, a ballistic missile hit a residential neighborhood in Beit Shemesh on March 1, killing nine civilians in what became the single deadliest incident on Israeli soil during the conflict.

By the tenth day of the conflict, however, Iranian missile and drone attacks had dropped by more than 90 percent — a reduction analysts attributed to effective suppression efforts by US and Israeli forces, who are estimated to have eliminated up to three-quarters of Iran's remaining missile launchers. The dramatic decline suggested that Iran's vaunted missile arsenal, already degraded in the 2025 Twelve-Day War, had been catastrophically diminished.

Iran's Hezbollah allies in Lebanon also entered the conflict, launching attacks against Israel from the north. The Lebanese government — which has sought to disarm Hezbollah since the 2023-24 conflict — moved to ban Hezbollah military activities, prompting Israeli military operations against the group. In a sign of Iran's isolation, the Houthi movement in Yemen issued largely symbolic statements of solidarity rather than joining the fighting directly, constrained by its own ceasefire with the United States.

CASUALTY OVERVIEW (As of March 20, 2026)

Location	Killed	Wounded / Notes
Iran	1,444+	2,000+ wounded; 29 of 31 provinces struck
Israel	18+	Dozens wounded; Beit Shemesh worst-hit
US Military	13	Bases in Bahrain, Iraq, Kuwait targeted
Gulf States	21+	Bahrain, Kuwait, UAE; energy sites struck
Iraq	61+	Mostly PMF paramilitary forces
Jordan	0 dead	28 injured

Sources: Al Jazeera, Iranian Health Ministry, US CENTCOM, ACLED

THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ AND GLOBAL ECONOMIC FALLOUT

Perhaps the most consequential single action of the conflict was Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz — the narrow waterway through which roughly 20 percent of the world's oil passes. Iranian forces mined the strait, attacked commercial shipping, and struck Gulf energy infrastructure, causing oil and gas prices to surge worldwide. Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, and the United Arab Emirates all reported Iranian attacks on energy sites after Israel struck Iran's South Pars gasfield — one of the world's largest natural gas fields.

The European Union called for the immediate reopening of the strait and an end to strikes on energy and water infrastructure. US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced measures to ease spiking oil prices. A coalition of nations, including the US and European partners, warned Iran to cease its mining and drone activity and pledged to contribute to ensuring safe passage for commercial shipping.

INTERNATIONAL REACTION

The conflict triggered a sharp global diplomatic response. The United Nations and the majority of nations expressed deep concern and called for an immediate return to diplomacy. Most Muslim-majority and Arab states condemned the strikes. Some international legal scholars and the International Commission of Jurists characterized the Israeli and US attacks as violations of international law.

A smaller group of countries — including the United States, Germany, Ukraine, and Argentina — argued the strikes were justified to prevent nuclear proliferation and called on Iran to agree to a nuclear deal promptly. The UK declined to participate militarily. Prime Minister Keir Starmer, in a joint statement with French and German leaders, condemned Iranian counter-strikes while stating clearly he did not believe in 'regime change from the skies.' The UK did, however, confirm defensive military actions to protect British forces in the region.

WHAT COMES NEXT

With Khamenei dead, Iran's political future is deeply uncertain. His son has been named as successor, but the legitimacy and durability of the new leadership remains unclear amid ongoing strikes and domestic instability. The stated US and Israeli objectives — disabling Iran's nuclear program, destroying its ballistic missile capabilities, and inducing regime change — remain partially fulfilled at best.

Iran's nuclear program, despite significant damage in the June 2025 conflict, had been partially reconstituted. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) discovered, just days before the February 28 strikes, that Iran had concealed highly enriched uranium in an underground facility that had survived the 2025 bombing. Whether the 2026 campaign has permanently dismantled that program remains one of the conflict's defining open questions.

As of March 20, 2026, the conflict shows no imminent signs of a negotiated end. The Strait of Hormuz remains closed. Iranian retaliatory fire continues, though at greatly reduced intensity. The death toll mounts daily across a region that, for the past three years, has lurched from crisis to crisis — and now finds itself in the most dangerous chapter yet.